

39 Caleb

The spy who "wholly followed the LORD" and at eighty-five asked for a mountain.

Caleb was one of twelve men Moses sent to explore Canaan. Ten came back afraid of giants and walled cities. Only Caleb and Joshua urged the people to trust God and go in. The people wanted to stone them, and God sentenced that whole generation to die in the wilderness. But he made an exception for Caleb, because he "hath followed me fully." Forty-five years later, at eighty-five, Caleb was still strong. He asked for the hill country of Hebron, where the giants lived, and he took it. His story is about faith that does not fade with age, and about a man who waited decades for a promise and never gave up on it.

At a glance

Name	Kalev, linked to "dog," perhaps "faithful" or "bold"
Family	Son of Jephunneh the Kenezite, of the tribe of Judah (Numbers 13:6; 32:12)
Daughter	Achsah, wife of Othniel (Joshua 15:16–17)
Lifespan	Age 40 as a spy; still strong at 85 (Joshua 14:7, 10–11)
Inheritance	Hebron and the hill country around it (Joshua 14:13–14)
Key people	Moses, Joshua, Othniel, the sons of Anak
Main passages	Numbers 13–14; Joshua 14:6–15; 15:13–19
New Testament	Not named

"But my servant Caleb, because he had another spirit with him, and hath followed me fully, him will I bring into the land whereinto he went; and his seed shall possess it."

Numbers 14:24, KJV

The life of Caleb

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. His ages come from Joshua 14:7–10.

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| c. 1445 BC
<i>Age 40</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Sent as a spy
Moses chooses one leader from each tribe to search the land of Canaan. Caleb represents Judah. For forty days the spies explore the land, including Hebron. <i>Numbers 13:1–25; Joshua 14:7</i></div></div> |
| c. 1445 BC
<i>Age 40</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Calls for courage
Ten spies say the people are too strong. Caleb quiets the crowd: "Let us go up at once, and possess it; for we are well able to overcome it." <i>Numbers 13:26–33</i></div></div> |
| c. 1445 BC
<i>Age 40</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Spared from the sentence
The people weep and want new leaders. Caleb and Joshua tear their clothes and plead with them. God declares that of all the adults only these two will enter the land. <i>Numbers 14:1–38</i></div></div> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>Age 79</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Chosen to divide the land
On the plains of Moab, God names Caleb as Judah's leader for dividing the land of Canaan among the tribes. <i>Numbers 26:65; 34:16–19</i></div></div> |
| c. 1400 BC
<i>Age 85</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Asks for the mountain
At Gilgal he reminds Joshua of Moses' promise and asks for the hill country where the giants live. Joshua blesses him and gives him Hebron. <i>Joshua 14:6–15</i></div></div> |
| c. 1400 BC or later | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Takes Hebron
He drives out the three sons of Anak and offers his daughter Achsah to whoever takes Kirjath-sepher. Othniel wins her, and Caleb gives her springs of water. <i>Joshua 15:13–19</i></div></div> |

Key activities

Caleb is called "the Kenezite." Kenaz is also an Edomite clan name (Genesis 36:11, 42), so some think Caleb's family was not Israelite by birth but joined the tribe of Judah. Others think Kenaz was simply an ancestor in Judah. The text does not say.

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- 1 **Saw the same land differently.** He saw the same giants as the others but trusted God's promise. *Numbers 13:30; 14:6-9*
 - 2 **Stood against the crowd.** He and Joshua told the people, "the LORD is with us: fear them not," even as the people talked of stoning them. *Numbers 14:9-10*
 - 3 **Followed the LORD fully.** God himself gave Caleb this testimony, and Moses and Joshua repeated it. *Numbers 14:24; Deuteronomy 1:36; Joshua 14:8-9, 14*
 - 4 **Waited forty-five years.** He wandered with a faithless generation for a sin that was not his, then fought for the land. *Joshua 14:10*
 - 5 **Asked for the hardest place.** "Now therefore give me this mountain," he said, where the Anakim lived. *Joshua 14:12*
 - 6 **Won Hebron.** He drove out Sheshai, Ahiman and Talmai, the three sons of Anak. *Joshua 15:13-14; Judges 1:20*
 - 7 **Blessed his daughter.** When Achsah asked for springs, he gave her "the upper springs, and the nether springs." *Joshua 15:18-19; Judges 1:12-15*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Caleb.

Old Testament

Numbers 13-14	The spying of the land and God's verdict
Numbers 32:11-12; Deuteronomy 1:34-36	Only Caleb and Joshua will see the land
Numbers 34:19	Judah's leader for dividing the land
Joshua 14:6-15; 15:13-19; 21:11-12	He receives Hebron's fields
Judges 1:10-15, 20	Hebron taken; Achsah's springs
1 Samuel 25:3; 1 Chronicles 4:15	Nabal of Caleb's house; Caleb's sons

New Testament

Hebrews 3:16-4:2	That generation could not enter "because of unbelief"
1 Corinthians 10:1-11	Wilderness events written "for our admonition"
Echo: 2 Timothy 4:7	"I have kept the faith"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Caleb see in Canaan, and what did he say about it (Numbers 13:30; 14:6-9)?
2. *Understand:* What do you think it means that Caleb had "another spirit" and "wholly followed the LORD"?
3. *Apply:* Caleb asked for the hardest place at 85. What challenge might God be giving you now?
4. *Apply:* Where do you need to speak up for faith when the crowd around you is afraid?